ever our numbers, we will try to be the main opposition party in the assembly," said AAP spokesperson Yogesh Jadwani. The decade-old party managed just five seats but came second in 36, pushing the Congress to third place. A stable aspect of Gujarat's recent voting patterns has been the BJP being predominant in the urban areas with the Congress holding its own in the rural sections. Since some 45 per cent of the populace is now urban, the BJP built outward from that base and this made for relatively resilient vote shares.

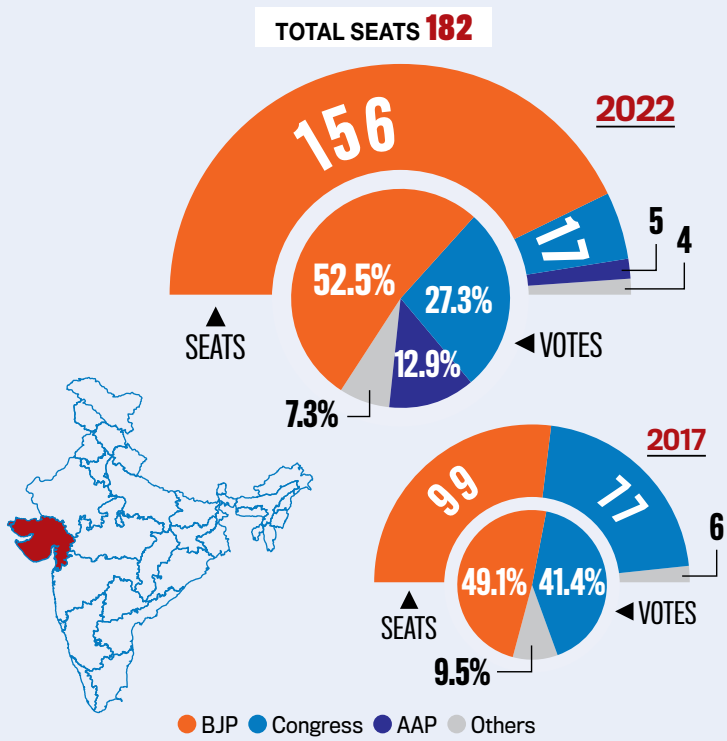
This election has upended that pattern, with the Congress losing 40 per cent of its vote share in both rural and urban seats, primarily to AAP. The party's performance—down to 17 seats from the 77 it won in 2017—was a logical outcome of its near-invisible campaign, betraying a defeatist lethargy. Even Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra conspicuously avoided Gujarat. As the leaders stayed away, so did the loyal but frustrated Congress voter. Of those who did vote, says BJP spokesperson Yamal Vyas, "half came to the BJP, the rest was bagged by AAP."

Meanwhile, the BJP's 'carpet bombing' campaign, now de rigueur for almost any election the party is fighting, was raised to another level in Gujarat. While Modi took out some 31 rallies, Union home minister Amit Shah was practically living here. Then there was the procession of over 150 national leaders, cabinet ministers and BJP chief ministers who campaigned aggressively all over the state. In fact, a running joke in Gujarat was that the BJP was working like it was the underdog desperate to catch up. The frenetic pace despite the party's obvious popularity led some to wonder whether the perception about the BJP's victory was more hype than reality—did the party know something the rest did not? That said, no one was in doubt about the results, but few believed the BJP would actually surpass the anti-incumbency barrier to break 'Narendra's record'.

The party focus had been on two factors that had brought them down

A NEW ELECTION RECORD

A BJP whirlwind hits the west coast in Gujarat



Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

